PRIVATE COLLECTION | NIGERIA

MUYIWA AKINWOLERE

Figures, Line & the Living Surface

Selected works, 2009 and 2013
International gallery catalogue



Collection of Ozuwo Enifome

OCTOBER 2026

A gathering of presences

Presented from 2009 to 2013, these thirteen works show the human figure is sometimes recognisable and sometimes dispersed into colour, contour and gesture. Wide eyes invite an encounter; overlapping bodies complicate the distinction between one person and another. In the abstract compositions, that same instability survives as a meeting of curved forms and interrupted outlines.

The works dated 2013 bring transparent-looking washes into dialogue with controlled drawing. Ochre, brown and cream form a warm ground for turquoise, blue and rose. Patterned clothing and elongated bodies connect intimate encounters to larger gatherings, while blank intervals and shifts of scale give each scene its particular tension.

In My Small Family, the raised hand and enlarged central figure organise the surrounding faces. Unbelonging makes the space between a group and an individual expressive. In Between Two Loves compresses three figures into an intimate arrangement, leaving proximity and divided attention to carry the emotional charge.

The four acrylic works dated 2009 present a different register. Red and yellow grounds, dense black marks and compact shapes give these smaller sheets a forceful presence. One composition holds its repeated vertical forms inside a rounded enclosure; others assemble mask-like fragments or gather lines into a charged central mass.

These contrasts make the collection more than a sequence of similar images. The 2009 and 2013 groups offer distinct ways of balancing structure and disruption: enclosure against movement, repeated shape against individual gesture, and recognisable faces against forms that resist a stable identity. The selection alone does not establish a complete account of the artist's development.

Akinwolere's contribution is especially apparent in the way he makes line perform several tasks at once. It describes a face, divides a coloured field and then becomes an independent rhythm. The surface remains active even where the subject seems still. Together, the works invite close attention to the relationship between a person, a mark and the space around them.

Between the figure and the imagined

ABSTRACTION AS A DISTINCTIVE STRAND

Abstraction forms a significant strand within this selection. In several works, Muyiwa Akinwolere moves beyond recognisable figures to construct compositions from interlocking curves, angular marks, transparent-looking washes and patterned compartments. Fragments suggest an eye, a hand or a body, yet resist becoming a fixed subject. The viewer moves between recognition and uncertainty.

Particularly distinctive is the way Akinwolere allows line to change its function. A contour that appears to describe a face becomes the boundary of a colour field, then continues as an independent gesture. His abstract compositions retain something of the human encounters found in his figurative works: forms gather, overlap, separate and compete for space.

This relationship makes abstraction integral to the collection's visual language. It is both a subject in its own right and a means of transforming the figure. In MA-03, for example, an enlarged eye and dislocated facial features remain readable within an emphatically invented structure.

CONTRASTING APPROACHES: 2009 AND 2013

The selected acrylic works dated 2009 favour concentrated shapes, forceful black marks and strong red and yellow contrasts. MA-01 holds repeated vertical forms within a rounded enclosure; MA-02 and MA-04 organise their energy through overlapping strokes and compressed shapes. MA-03 brings abstraction into direct contact with a mask-like face.

The abstractions dated 2013 offer a different rhythm. MA-06 brings cool turquoise into an interwoven field of warm colour; MA-07 combines broad gestures with finer drawing and pale openings; MA-10 builds a dense exchange between dark enclosures and luminous reserves. Their individual character lies in how each balances movement, pattern and space.

Together, these works demonstrate a range of approaches to abstraction. The contrast between the two dated groups is visible in this selection, but does not establish a complete chronology of the artist's development. These observations are editorial interpretations of the photographed works.

Muyiwa Akinwolere

CONTEMPORARY NIGERIAN ARTIST | FIGURATION & ABSTRACTION | BORN 1976

Muyiwa Akinwolere is a Nigerian artist whose practice brings figurative invention, fluid colour and social observation into conversation. He studied Fine Art at Obafemi Awolowo University, Ile-Ife. Gallery biographies describe an early upbringing in Osogbo and an engagement with Susanne Wenger and artists associated with the Osogbo tradition. [1]

Figuration and abstraction meet within the visual language of this selection. Human features emerge from, and dissolve into, arrangements of line, colour and pattern. His figures occupy a space between the familiar and the imagined. Enlarged eyes, elongated bodies and interwoven contours give ordinary gatherings an unsettled, sometimes quietly comic presence. Curator Mathew Oyedele relates the characteristic facial forms to Osogbo soapstone sculpture and describes a practice attentive to satire and social commentary. [2]

In a 2018 interview, Akinwolere described combining hantu, a traditional plant-derived dye used for Arabic calligraphy, with other inks in a process he calls antique ink. He has also worked with recycled metal, including beverage cans and aluminium printing plates. [3]

His broader practice addresses mythology, migration, inequality and political power. ENO Gallery records a Ventures Africa residency in 2016 and an Afrika Now residency in 2020, connecting these periods to work on terror, displacement and conspiracy theories. Its biography places his studio practice in Badagry. [1]

Institutional documentation includes Kowina (2011), an oil painting presented by the Yemisi Shyllon Museum of Art on Google Arts & Culture. Lasmara separately records Bundle of Joy (2012) as antique ink on canvas, demonstrating that his antique-ink work extends across supports. [4, 5]

The present selection comprises works recorded by the collector as gouache and ink, acrylic and ink, and acrylic on paper. These individual media should be distinguished from the artist's broader material practice; antique ink is not assumed for any work in this catalogue.

Exhibitions & professional context

SELECTED SOLO EXHIBITIONS

2022 Introspection

Thought Pyramid Art Centre, Ikoyi, Lagos, 10-30 December. Earlier presentation at Yusuf Grillo Gallery, Yaba College of Technology, Lagos, November. [2]

2018 Those That Were Crushed

Whitespace Gallery, Lagos. Documented in an interview dated 1 May 2018, with the exhibition scheduled to continue until 5 May. [3]

2013 Mirror-Mirror

French Institute, Abuja. Recorded in SOGAL's 2016 artist biography. [6]

2011 Once Upon a Time

Pan-African University, Lagos. Recorded in SOGAL's 2016 artist biography. [6]

SELECTED GROUP EXHIBITION

2017 - Lagos Biennial
Participation reported by the artist in his 2018 interview. [3]

RESIDENCIES

2020 - Afrika Now, Lagos. [1]

2016 - Ventures Africa, six-month residency. [1]

INSTITUTIONAL REFERENCE

Kowina, 2011, oil on canvas.
Yemisi Shyllon Museum of Art record on Google Arts & Culture. [4]

Selected published records. Participation by the artist does not establish that works in this collection were exhibited at these events.

MA-01 | 2009



MUYIWA AKINWOLERE

Untitled

2009
Acrylic on paper
12 × 10 in (30.5 × 25.4 cm)

A rounded yellow enclosure stands against a red ground, its dark edge broken by white reserves and scattered marks. Repeated black vertical slots run through the form, crossed at the centre by a broad blue band. The arrangement can suggest a grille, an emblem or a bodily structure, but none of these associations settles the image. Akinwolere gives a simple framework considerable force through repetition and colour contrast. Scraped-looking interruptions and uneven edges prevent the structure from becoming mechanical, while the blue crossband draws the separate vertical elements into a single compact presence. The composition holds its energy within a deliberately restricted vocabulary. Its abstraction depends on the repeated shape and enclosing contour, allowing associations to emerge without fixing a literal subject.

Collection: Ozuwo Enifome, Nigeria.
Object particulars supplied by the collector.
See Collection Records for provenance, condition and measurement notes.

MA-02 | 2009



MUYIWA AKINWOLERE

Untitled

2009
Acrylic on paper
12 × 10 in (30.5 × 25.4 cm)

Angular black strokes sweep across a red and yellow field, gathering around dark rounded masses and fragments of green and blue. The upper green passage introduces a relatively stable plane, while the lines below appear to cut, bind and redirect the surrounding colour. Akinwolere makes the meeting of structure and impulse visible: broad coloured areas provide temporary anchors that the restless drawing repeatedly disturbs. Face-like associations emerge from the arrangement without becoming a fixed portrait. The work's character lies in this unresolved construction, where a compact sheet carries the intensity of a much larger gestural field. Here abstraction is driven by the collision of line and colour rather than a stable subject or setting.

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MA-03 | 2009



MUYIWA AKINWOLERE

Untitled

2009
Acrylic on paper
12 × 10 in (30.5 × 25.4 cm)

An enlarged eye anchors a compact assembly of angular planes, curved shapes and black contours. Turquoise, green, ochre and violet interrupt the red ground, while an open mouth-like form near the lower centre gives the image an animated, almost vocal quality. Akinwolere constructs a face through dislocation rather than anatomical continuity. Its fragments remain readable even as their shifting directions unsettle the whole. The strong black framework binds the contrasting colours, and the surrounding red heightens their presence. The result is a mask-like figure whose expressive force comes from the tension between recognisable features and an emphatically invented structure. The enlarged eye acts as a bridge between figurative recognition and abstract invention.

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MA-04 | 2009



MUYIWA AKINWOLERE

Untitled

2009
Acrylic on paper
12 × 10 in (30.5 × 25.4 cm)

A dark central mass is enclosed by sweeping black curves and intersected by angular strokes. Red surrounds the form, with pale areas along the left edge and smaller blue and cream passages breaking through the upper and lower sections. Akinwolere organises the composition through density: marks accumulate toward the centre, while the lighter perimeter gives that concentration an uneven boundary. The shapes can evoke a compressed head or an enclosed body, but the image sustains several readings. His handling of overlapping lines gives the surface a restless depth, making enclosure feel active and unstable rather than still or sealed. Abstraction becomes an experience of compression, with the central shape continually unsettled by the marks that contain it.

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MA-05 | 2013



MUYIWA AKINWOLERE

My Small Family

2013
Gouache and ink on paper
29 × 20 in (73.7 × 50.8 cm)

A large central figure rises above an assembly of smaller faces, its raised hand interrupting the dark wash behind it. Red stripes and patterned garments carry the eye through the lower field, where bodies press together without losing their separate expressions. Akinwolere transforms the group portrait into an arrangement of unequal scales: presence is measured by pictorial space rather than natural anatomy. The oversized eyes introduce an alert, questioning mood, while the delicate contours keep the gathering buoyant. Authority, care and collective attention become possible readings of a scene that declines to settle into a single narrative.

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MA-06 | 2013



MUYIWA AKINWOLERE

Untitled

2013
Gouache and ink on paper
21.6 × 18 in (54.9 × 45.7 cm)

Turquoise passages move through a warm field of brown and cream, caught within a network of looping black lines. Small areas of hatching interrupt the broad colour shapes, introducing a quieter, closely worked rhythm. Here Akinwolere allows drawing to slip between description and abstraction: a hand-like fragment offers recognition, then dissolves into the surrounding curves. The cool colour opens intervals within the dense structure and gives the visible passage a distinctive freshness. His contribution lies in keeping that uncertainty active, so the image can be followed as both an encounter of forms and a field of movement. The shifting roles of contour and colour make this a distinctive meeting of abstraction and bodily suggestion.

Collection: Ozuwo Enifome, Nigeria.
Object particulars supplied by the collector.
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MA-07 | 2013



MUYIWA AKINWOLERE

Untitled

2013
Gouache and ink on paper
30 × 18 in (76.2 × 45.7 cm)

Sweeping black gestures cross a field of amber, olive and pale reserves. Fine lines trace smaller shapes beneath the heavier marks, while spirals and hand-like fragments appear briefly before being absorbed into the wider movement. The concentration of activity above gradually loosens toward the lower edge. Akinwolere transforms the surface into a conversation between control and release: precise drawing offers a structure that the broad strokes repeatedly disturb. The varied weight of his marks gives the abstraction its physical energy, and the openings below allow the composition to breathe without bringing its restless movement to a stop. Its abstract language preserves the suggestion of living forms while allowing the marks an independent rhythm.

Collection: Ozuwo Enifome, Nigeria.
Object particulars supplied by the collector.
See Collection Records for provenance, condition and measurement notes.

MA-08 | 2013



MUYIWA AKINWOLERE

Unbelonging

2013
Gouache and ink on paper
30 × 18 in (76.2 × 45.7 cm)

A dense gathering occupies the left side, facing a solitary figure across a passage of rose and charcoal wash. Tall bodies and enlarged eyes establish a common visual language, yet the empty interval keeps the two sides apart. Akinwolere makes distance expressive: the space becomes as consequential as the people who surround it. Interlocking faces complicate the group's identity, while the separate figure retains a clear profile. The artist turns a simple arrangement of bodies into an unresolved human encounter, allowing questions of belonging, scrutiny and separation to emerge through composition rather than an explicit story.

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Object particulars supplied by the collector.
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MA-09 | 2013



MUYIWA AKINWOLERE

Untitled

2013
Gouache and ink on paper
30 × 18 in (76.2 × 45.7 cm)

Faces overlap across a warm field of red, ochre and rose, with a bright orange shirt holding the left-centre of the composition. Some figures look outward; others turn inward or appear to share the same outline. Slender bodies extend below the crowded upper field, carrying intricate bands of line and pattern. Akinwolere transforms the gathering into a structure of connected identities, where one person's boundary becomes another's beginning. The contrast between wide eyes and quieter, half-closed lids enriches the emotional register. It is the distribution of attention, as much as the figures themselves, that gives the work its presence.

Collection: Ozuwo Enifome, Nigeria.
Object particulars supplied by the collector.
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MA-10 | 2013



MUYIWA AKINWOLERE

Untitled

2013
Gouache and ink on paper
29.5 × 22.5 in (74.9 × 57.1 cm)

A dense network of rounded shapes fills the sheet, alternating warm brown and cream with deep blue-black passages. Small bands of stripes and triangular pattern interrupt the larger curves, while rings and pale openings suggest eyes, mouths or fragments of bodies without resolving into fixed figures. Akinwolere makes abstraction feel inhabited: forms seem to lean into, surround and absorb one another. His balance of dark enclosures and luminous reserves keeps the crowded field legible, allowing the eye to move between intimate details and the larger rhythm. The result is a composition whose energy comes from continual exchange between recognisable fragments and independent shapes. This is an abstraction sustained by the possibility of recognition, rather than the complete disappearance of the figure.

Collection: Ozuwo Enifome, Nigeria.
Object particulars supplied by the collector.
See Collection Records for provenance, condition and measurement notes.

MA-11 | 2013



MUYIWA AKINWOLERE

In Between Two Loves

2013
Gouache and ink on paper
25.5 × 20 in (64.8 × 50.8 cm)

Three elongated figures stand close together against a mottled blue and pale ground. The central figure, marked by a striped tie, is flanked by two profiles whose large eyes and inward-facing poses concentrate attention within the group. Overlapping contours compress the space, making the figures appear physically connected while their expressions remain difficult to read. Akinwolere turns proximity into an emotional question: the title introduces divided affection, but the image leaves the precise relationships unresolved. The cool setting steadies the warmer faces and patterned clothing, giving this intimate encounter a quiet tension rather than an explicit dramatic conclusion.

Collection: Ozuwo Enifome, Nigeria.
Object particulars supplied by the collector.
See Collection Records for provenance, condition and measurement notes.

MA-12 | 2013



MUYIWA AKINWOLERE

Untitled

2013
Acrylic and ink on paper
12 × 16 in (30.5 × 40.6 cm)

A large head and extended hand dominate the left side, facing a smaller figure who looks upward from the lower right. Above them, pale geometric forms and looping contours occupy a vivid blue field, interrupting any simple distinction between people and their surroundings. Akinwolere uses differences of scale to make the exchange psychologically charged. The open hands suggest communication, appeal or explanation, while the oversized eyes keep the encounter alert. His fusion of figurative drawing and abstract compartments allows the surrounding space to participate in the conversation, turning a compact horizontal composition into a lively negotiation of attention and response.

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MA-13 | 2013



MUYIWA AKINWOLERE

Untitled

2013
Acrylic and ink on paper
12 × 16 in (30.5 × 40.6 cm)

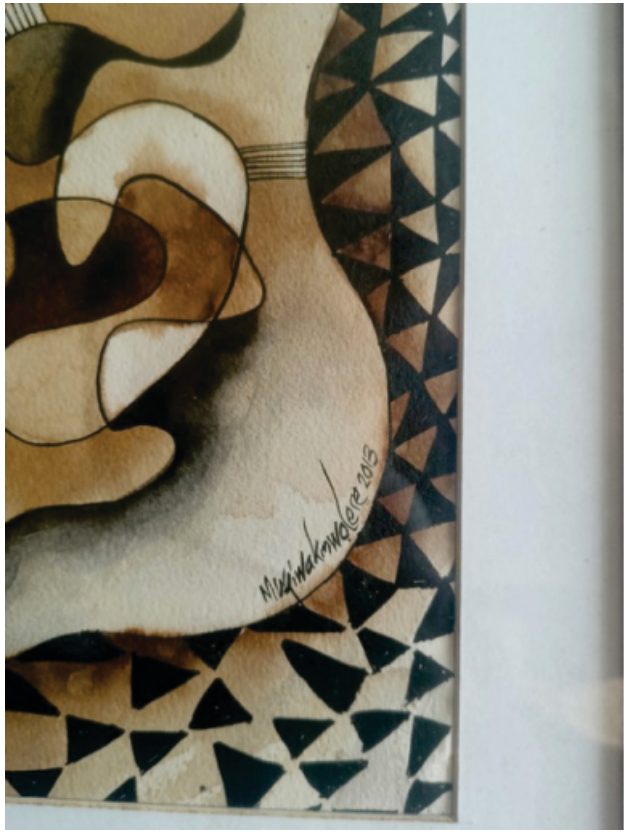
Two mask-like faces occupy the centre of a red field, accompanied by small fish forms and a band of blue, cream and ochre compartments across the upper area. Narrow eyes, patterned cheeks and interlocking outlines give the heads a shared rhythm without making their expressions identical. Akinwolere sets the warm background against cool blue passages, creating a visual tension that keeps the densely assembled forms distinct. Fish and floating shapes introduce an imaginative environment rather than a literal setting. His achievement lies in bringing figures, signs and colour into a unified surface, where each detail contributes to the composition's pulse.

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Object particulars supplied by the collector.
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Inscription details



DETAIL A



DETAIL B

Two supplied photographic details record signatures and dates appearing to read 2013. They are reproduced as supporting visual records.

Their correspondence to specific entries among MA-01 to MA-13 has not been verified. No catalogue number is assigned here.

These images do not constitute independent authentication or artist-issued certificates.

Provenance & object documentation

COLLECTION AND ACQUISITION HISTORY

The thirteen works are presented as the private collection of Ozuwo Enifome, Nigeria. Individual acquisition dates, sources and methods have not been supplied for this edition. Direct acquisition from the artist is not asserted. Any invoices, correspondence or transfer records should be associated with the relevant catalogue number.

DATES, TITLES AND MEDIA

Entries follow the collector's revised file: four works dated 2009 precede nine works dated 2013. Order within each year is editorial; exact creation dates are unavailable. Media are recorded as gouache and ink, acrylic and ink, or acrylic on paper. These object particulars have not been independently authenticated. Untitled is used where no title is supplied; named titles follow the collector's record.

INTERPRETATION

Artwork commentaries are editorial readings of the supplied photographs. Suggested meanings are interpretations, not confirmed statements of the artist's intention. The selection does not establish a complete chronology of the artist's practice.

MEASUREMENTS

Dimensions are reproduced in the order supplied by the collector; centimetres are converted from inches and rounded to one decimal place. The source does not establish whether all dimensions refer to the image, paper sheet or frame, or consistently follow height before width. These distinctions require confirmation before a sale.

CONDITION AND PHOTOGRAPHY

The collector reported excellent condition on 23 October 2026. No independent physical examination has been undertaken. The photographs alone cannot exclude foxing, fading, tears, mount-related damage or repairs. Work-specific condition reports and reverse photographs remain to be supplied. Images are reproduced without generated reconstruction or intentional colour alteration.

AUTHENTICITY AND SUPPORTING RECORDS

Signature details are currently unassigned. Artist-issued certificates, where available, should be matched to each work. Unique-original status and any reproduction or edition history remain to be confirmed. No individual exhibition or publication history is established by this catalogue.

Sources & editorial notes

1 ENO Gallery. Muyiwa Akinwolere, artist biography.
View source

2 Tajudeen Sowole / A-ARTs. Introspection of Akinwolere's visual tale goes to Thought Pyramid. 8 December 2022.
View source

3 The Arts-Muse Fair. I wanted to stay up-north to practice but... Muyiwa Akinwolere, Visual Artist. Interview, 1 May 2018.
View source

4 Yemisi Shyllon Museum of Art / Google Arts & Culture. Kowina, Muyiwa Akinwolere, 2011.
View source

5 Lasmara. Muyiwa Akinwolere: Bundle of Joy, 2012, artwork record and artist profile.
View source

6 Signature Beyond. TALENT: Contemporary & Modern SOGAL Art Auction, March 2016. Biography accompanying lot 8.
View source

References reviewed and source links added on 25 October 2026. Published biographies differ on birthplace; this edition retains the reported birth year and omits a birthplace.

The artist's general biography and exhibition history do not authenticate the works in this collection. This catalogue does not issue a valuation or an independently verified condition opinion.

PRIVATE COLLECTION | NIGERIA

Ozuwo Enifome

Collection enquiries and requests for supporting documentation

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Availability, prices and commercial terms are supplied separately.